

What is possible in debuccalo-verhauchung? Was there $d > h$ in Chamorro?

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In remarkable work dealing in depth with phonological change in Austronesian, Blust (2013, 613) writes that “[a]mong the rare lenitive changes of $*d$ that are noteworthy is $*d > h$ in Chamorro, which may have passed through stages $*d > r > h$.” In this talk, I focus on the changes proposed in this passage, considering them in the context of both diachronic phonological typology and the wider phonological history of Chamorro. Is it right to see $d > h$ as ‘noteworthy’? Is the intermediate stage that Blust proposes plausible? I argue that a change of the type $d > h$ would indeed be noteworthy. In fact, I claim that $d > h$ is an *impossible change* (that is: $d \not> h$, as a ‘direct’ monoquantal endogenous change). In order to make the claim that $d \not> h$, I need to show two things: (i) that it is compatible with the empirical record of changes that we can confidently recognise in diachronic typology, and (ii) that there is an explanation in terms of (historical) phonological theory as to why it should be impossible.

(i) requires an engagement with the best records that we have of cases of the kind of change that can result in h (such as, but not limited to, Kümmel 2007). The most common diachronic source of h is what I call ‘debuccalo-verhauchung’ (*debuccalo-* for the loss of oral – ‘buccal’ – specification and *verhauchung* to show that the result is h , as h is the ‘Hauchlaut’). Canonical cases of debuccalo-verhauchung typically involve a fortis fricative as the change’s input – not a lenis stop (or sonorant). I interrogate the typological record and argue that this observation holds up: no case of $d > h$ (nor any lenis stop $> h$) has been firmly attested as a direct change.

(ii) requires a (historical) theoretical account which predicts that h cannot result from d . I show how the long-standing argument that there can be a representational control on phonological innovation provides a framework for this and that a compelling strand of argumentation in this tradition, as in Lass (1976), Goldsmith (1979), McCarthy (1988), Keyser & Stevens 1994 (and possibly Backley 2011), predicts that d is not a possible diachronic source for h because of the subsegmental make-up of d (and h).

Acknowledging that $d > h$ is an impossible change does not mean that $d : h$ is an impossible diachronic correspondence, of course (and the synchronic $d : h$ correspondence between most other Austronesian languages and Chamorro is robust). But it does mean that multiple changes must be involved (entailing ‘intermediate stages’). Blust’s proposal ($d > r$ and then $r > h$) may be surprising on the basis of classically canonical cases of debuccalo-verhauchung, but I show that there indeed is a diachronic pathway through which rhotics have become h in the history of languages (not as a direct change, though – a set of changes were involved, ending in a case of debuccalo-verhauchung). I argue, however, that there is a more plausible diachronic pathway from d to h in Chamorro than the one that Blust proposes, which fits well with what we know of the typical patterning of debuccalo-verhauchung, and involves only changes (in the d to h pathway) which are otherwise needed to explain the phonological history of the language.

References

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